DAYMOND JOHN

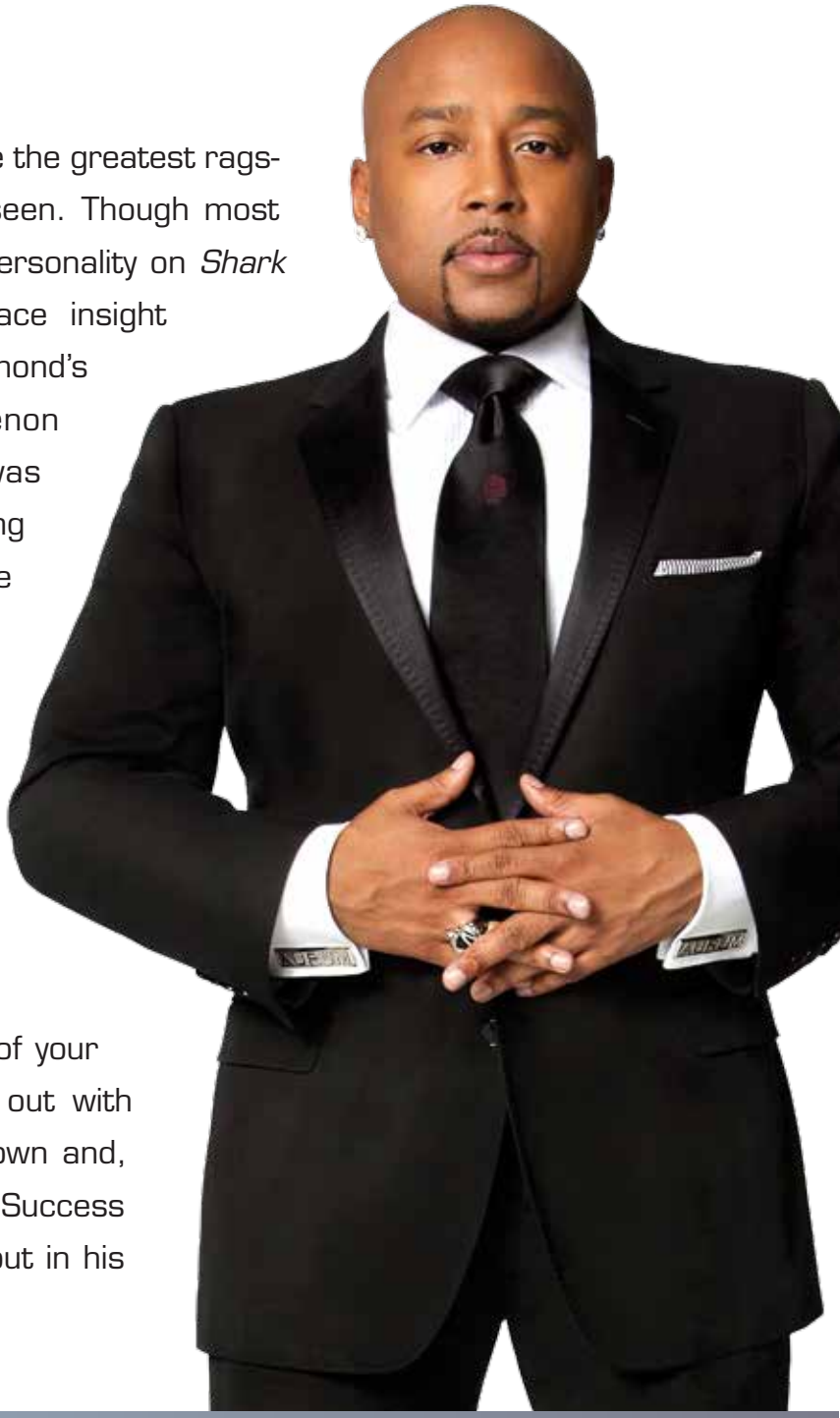
Stepping UP for SUCCESS

DAYMOND JOHN'S LAUNCH ACADEMY

DAYMOND JOHN

Introduction

Daymond John's star has been cast alongside the greatest rags-to-riches entrepreneurs America has ever seen. Though most people are familiar with his larger-than-life personality on *Shark Tank*, few really understand the marketplace insight and competitive spirit it took to build Daymond's company FUBU into a pop culture phenomenon and a $6 billion brand. Daymond's path was not an easy one. From dirt-poor kid hawking shirts and hats out of a duffel bag outside the Jamaica Colosseum in Queens, to global business mogul who built his brand on hard work, dedication and exceptional quality — Daymond's creative vision and tenacious determination have made him one of the most renowned and respected business leaders in the world.



Do you think success like Daymond's is out of your reach? **It's not.** Chances are, he started out with less than you may have — but he gritted down and, with a burning desire to succeed, applied 5 Success Principles to his life, which you can hear about in his own words .

"We reach for what we want, and there are no short cuts."
– Daymond John

Despite what you might think, I'm not really a fancy kind of guy. I was raised on the streets of New York and I'm just not afraid to tell it like it is. So forgive my bluntness, but… there's a reason you're reading my eBook right now. I don't know where you've come from, I don't know what dreams and goals you've got in your heart — but I do know that right here, at this very moment, you're meant to be reading this. I mean, what are the chances?

There are hundreds of thousands of eBooks, probably more, available to download, but somehow you found your way to me. I consider that a privilege, and it's also something I call "fate" — the same way that a few years ago, I had hundreds of voicemail messages and didn't bother to listen to any of them, except (miraculously) to the *one* left by Hollywood producer Mark Burnett, who had a little show he was putting together called *Shark Tank*, that he wanted me to be on…

So here I am. And here you are. There's a reason you're here. Let's get started.

1. YOUR WORD IS YOUR BOND.

When Mark Burnett's casting agents and producers were pitching me *hard* to be on *Shark Tank,* the concept just seemed crazy and one-sided at the time. It definitely wasn't a "slam dunk deal" in my mind — in my opinion there were flaws in the way they were proposing to run the show — and this issue came up very quickly. After an initial conference call with the producers, which resulted in my grilling them (instead of the other way around), we both decided that I would be a great asset to the show.

But I was still on the fence. I greatly respected Mark Burnett and the brand he'd built with *Survivor.* But this show was going to require me to put up my own money to back the contestants, and even more than that, to mentor them and put *my own reputation* on the line to help steer them to success. So, I told the producers I'd think about it. Well I guess that kind of lit a fire under them, and they called me back a couple days later. The producers told me they really wanted me and could they send over a contract for me to sign for the pilot series? Whoa, I didn't see that one coming!

Turns out the contract had an Exclusivity Clause in it, which meant that I couldn't appear as a regular on any other television show. That ended up being a big-time problem, because I was working with the Kardashians and I was going to be on E's Keeping up with the Kardashians as a coach and mentor to Khloe Kardashian. I'd already shot an episode with her and it had gone well, and the thought was that I could continue appearing on the show in that role for another four or five episodes. All told, I'd be on the air for maybe 10 or 15 minutes, tops. It was no big deal, but Khloe was a friend and I had given her my word.

I wouldn't go back on it for the *Shark Tank* opportunity — or for any other, either. So, I sent the contract back and explained the conflict: "Thanks, but no thanks," I told them. People thought I was crazy — especially in the entertainment industry. One of my agent friends called me and said, "Daymond, I've got superstar movie actor clients who would give their right arms to be on a prime time show, and you're giving it up for… what? Four or five minutes on an E! Channel show that has hardly been picked up for next season!"

"It's out of my hands, man," I said. "I gave Khloe my word." Sure, I could have asked Khloe if it was OK if I backed out — she probably would have told me I'd be crazy to miss out on this opportunity with Mark Burnett. But to me, that wouldn't have been cool. It would have gone against the personal brand I had spent my entire life building — and *would have undermined any credibility and integrity* I'd managed to collect along my way.

With me, my word is my brand. If it gets around that I can't be counted on, my word ends up being worthless. I would never get anywhere if people couldn't count on anything I said. So I make sure to stand behind what I say, and I follow through. What reflects on my brand, reflects on me – and you are only as good as your word.

You say I dream too big.
I say you think too small.

2. YOU *ARE* YOUR BRAND.

Whether you realize it or not, *you are your brand.* From where you live to what you wear… from the car you drive to which candidates you endorse. From the day you're born, you're branding yourself as one thing or another. You can't help it — and it will continue to the day you die. Like it or not, you will be "stamped", branded, and typecast — based on the choices you make, the people you associate with, the person you marry, the way you parent, the music you listen to, what you buy and what y*ou don't buy.*

It's a cumulative thing. The bottom line to all of this is that we live in an era of brand identity. Today's consumer wants to belong to a brand — to a movement, to an ideal. It used to be that the advertising types on Madison Avenue told us what to wear and what was cool. That power has now totally shifted and rests firmly in the hands of the consumer.

I remember hearing about this one incident with EA Sports and its consumers: EA Sports put out this golf game featuring Tiger Woods. One of the gamers posted a clip on YouTube, showing a flaw in the game, of Tiger teeing off on a pond. The clip ended up going viral, and EA Sports responded a short time later with a YouTube video of its own. "It's not a flaw," the video claimed. "He's just that good." Nice recovery, EA Sports!

But the fact that consumers now wield this kind of power over big companies was unthinkable even ten years ago. Consumers today want more and more to be part of a brand that represents something they believe in. Accordingly, businesses are looking for ways to create virtual communities and instill a sense of brand loyalty — to help launch new product lines, to reinvigorate tired lines and to provide valuable market research and feedback.

That's why your personal story is so important. Who you are, what do you stand for and why you are in the business you're in — is infinitely more powerful and more compelling to a consumer than reading some boring, official-sounding *corporate speak.* **You** are your greatest brand asset. Nurture your brand, grow it — and *protect it.*

3. HOT IDEAS DON'T DROP FROM THE SKY, FULLY FORMED.

You've got to go trolling for them. Good ideas are a dime a dozen. In a typical week, I get pitched at least 20 times by people looking for me to give them a leg up with their fledgling business, or to spot the gold in their crazy idea. Hot ideas really aren't that hard to come by.

Tough situations build strong people.

You know you've got one when it consumes you (and everyone around you) with *possibility.* It can fire up a business plan, excite potential investors, leap-frog traditional barriers to entry in a crowded marketplace, and turn up the heat on well-established competition. But a not-so-hot idea can dig a hole in the ground before you've even started — sucking up your time and energy and getting you moving so far in the wrong direction that, by the time you raise your head above the trenches from all your mis-steps, it's tough to scramble out and set things right.

People are always coming up to me and telling me how frustrated they are, saying that all the good business ideas are already gone (young people, especially). Honestly, that's just whining. I know, I used to whine about it, too. You've got to change your mindset about it and get out there hustling for opportunities, not just sit on your hands at home. Good ideas don't fall from the sky, perfectly formed — ready for you to hit a home run with. You've got to consider (and then re-consider) every idea, every prospect, from every angle.

Take a look at how your competitors are approaching their business, and find ways to do things better, harder. You've always got to be better, smarter, leaner than the other guy. There's obviously a lot more to it, and I go into that at my live entrepreneur training events, but for now I'll say this: even hot ideas can be shot with unexpected turns and disappointments.

The key is being nimble and flexible enough to take your business plan in a new direction if that's what's required, and *not* being married to your original idea. Learn from everything you do. Correct mistakes and move on from them. Most important — continue to act!

4. AIM HIGH. THEN AIM HIGHER.

One of my mom's favorite things to get me to do was to think big. She used to say to me, "Daymond, as long as you're thinking, you might as well be thinking big." Makes sense, right? One of my favorite quotes is from Christopher Reeve, a man who had overcome many of life's challenges; breaking into show business, having an amazing career, and to have it all taken away by a freak accident. "So many of our dreams seem impossible, then they seem improbable, and then, when we summon the will, they soon become inevitable." All I can add to that is, you have to be able to envision your dreams and make them your reality.

Whatever your business goals are, write them down and then pin them someplace where you can look at them at least once a day. *Your* life goals are just as important. You've probably heard about using a "mood board" to create a visual for yourself? That's what I used to create for our clothing lines, to give direction to our designers. In the beginning, I'd just rip out a bunch of pages from a magazine and tell them, "That's what I want!" One time, this made me think about doing

a military-inspired line, so I started pulling all these images of U.S. soldiers and handing them to our designers. They looked at me like I was crazy, but I wanted them to come up with a line of cargo pants and fatigue-style jackets that matched what was going on overseas, with the street sensibility that we wanted to reinforce back home.

The whole process made me realize that we should be doing mood boards for our personal lives — the person you want to become, the life you want to live. Thinking about creating one of these mood boards for yourself forces you to ask yourself a few hard questions:

Where are you in your life right now?
Where do you want to be by this time next year?
How about in five years?
What kinds of things do you really want out of life?

As you're doing this, you might as well take some advice from my mom and ***think big*** — that way, you've got something to shoot for and a direction to follow. Hey, as long as you're thinking… right?

Set goals. You cannot hit a target you cannot see.

5. GET ROLLING.

How many times have you kicked around a business idea with a friend? You say something like, "We ought to do this, we'll make a fortune!" We all see business opportunities. But the truth is, we hardly ever act. Make a decision today — to think big and act big. You need to have the attitude that ***you will never be stopped!*** Your effort and passion for your product or your service will produce sales.

And if you're someone who is just starting out, determined to start your own business (but not sure doing what, exactly) — that's OK, too.

Remember, the good ideas come to those to those who hustle. Surround yourself with like-minded thinkers, and be curious. Never stop learning.

You've got to take risks. What other people may call failure — is really only a stepping stone. Thomas Edison, after years of trying to make a lightbulb, said something like, "I've never failed, I've just discovered 10,000 ways not to do it." What would happen in your life, in your business, if you thought like that? Be your word, be your brand, think and think again about where you want to be, and ***think big.*** And never, never stop gunning for your goals.

"Align yourself with the right people, forge the right relationships, and you'll set yourself up for the long run."
– Daymond John